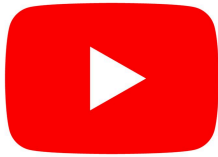


Case Study: Enhancing Long-Form Content Engagement on Youtube



Problem Statement:

YouTube as a platform is seeing a big change in how people watch videos. More users are now spending time on short videos (Shorts) instead of long videos that are 10 minutes or more.

Today, **billions of Shorts** are watched every day on YouTube. Because of AI tools, creators can quickly make and upload many short videos in less time. This has increased the number of Shorts on the platform a lot. With so many short videos available, they are taking more user attention.

Because of this shift, YouTube is facing a drop in engagement on long-form videos. Watch time on longer videos is going down, and fewer users are discovering deep, educational, or storytelling content. Many viewers now prefer fast entertainment and quick scrolling instead of spending time on one long video.

This creates a challenge for YouTube. Long videos are important for learning, meaningful watching, and creator earnings, but they are getting **less visibility**.

YouTube needs to understand how AI-driven content growth, changing user habits, and discovery gaps are affecting long-form video engagement on the platform.

The Challenge is to:

- Increase engagement on long-form videos (10+ minutes) on YouTube by helping users discover and watch more relevant long content, while still keeping the fun and fast experience of short videos.
- The goal is to create a better balance between short and long content so users enjoy both formats without feeling forced, and creators of long videos continue to get visibility and watch time on the platform.

Your Role as a Product Manager

As a Product Manager at YouTube, your role is to understand why people are watching fewer long videos by studying user behavior, watching patterns, and how AI and short videos are affecting the platform.

You need to find the main problems that are reducing views and discovery of long-form content. Based on your findings, you will suggest simple and useful solutions to improve engagement on long videos while keeping a good balance between short and long content for users.

Approach to Tackling the Problem

1. Understanding Pain Points

- User Research: Conduct surveys and interviews to identify why users favor short-form content and what could incentivize them to engage with long-form content. Understand specific needs, such as finding in-depth content within their preferred genres or balancing content variety.
- Competitor Benchmarking: Examine how other platforms like Netflix, TikTok, and Hulu manage short- and long-form content engagement, identifying strategies that could apply to YouTube.
- Behavioral Analysis: Analyze engagement data to determine drop-off points, patterns in long-form content consumption, and timeframes when users are more likely to engage with longer videos.

2. Build a Lateral View

- Try to come up with some crazy moonshot ideas to solve this problem which don't exist in the market currently (Vertical Solutions are also required here but 1 lateral idea is the name of the game!)

Structure of solution

You have to submit a “Problem space PRD” in detail - not more than 25 pages

Direction for the PRD:

1. Focus on Discovery-

- What is the exact problem?
- Why are we solving it?
- What are the current user behaviors?
- What do you think user behavior will change in the future?
- What does AI do in the context of the problem statement?

- What type of challenges will come while using AI for implementation?
- What are the user pain points from Youtube and User Side?
- What is the market that they operate in?

2. High Level solution along with the User Discovery

- Ensure solutions directly address user challenges and pain points identified during the discovery phase.
- Propose an innovative, out-of-the-box solution that is not currently in the market, focusing on high-impact and transformative results.
- Offer smaller, incremental improvements that support the overall solution, solving everyday user needs.
- Ensure the solution is scalable and adaptable to future changes in user behavior or technology advancements High-Level Picture of How It Will Work

Focus on Problem space first, if group feels there is no time for solution space its fine - dont worry you have ensure that do justice with the problem space rather than jumping to solution space- super super imp

Note: *Feel free to explore and find more references beyond this example- it's just to provide you with some direction. You're encouraged to make connections to additional ideas. It's not required to stick to this; use it as a reference and conduct your own discovery.*

Scoring Criteria

Discovery Phase (70 Points)

Element	Points	Description
Identifying the Exact Problem	20	Clearly define the core issue that needs to be addressed. Ensure understanding of why it's crucial for the platform and its users.
User Research & Pain Points	15	Conduct in-depth research to gather insights about current user behaviors and identify the main friction points affecting engagement.
Competitor Benchmarking	10	Analyze how competitors handle similar issues, extracting key learnings that could be applicable to the problem at hand.

Behavioral Analysis	10	Use data to understand user drop-off points, content preferences, and engagement patterns, especially concerning long-form vs. short-form content.
User Journey & Future Behavior	10	Anticipate potential shifts in user behavior and how it could affect the solution. Identify trends and patterns that may emerge.
Challenges in AI Implementation	5	Identify potential challenges in implementing AI-driven recommendations, both technical and user-experience-related.

2. Solution Phase (30 Points)

Element	Points	Description
Solution Solves Identified Pain Points	10	Ensure the solution directly addresses the pain points identified during discovery.
One Moonshot Idea (Lateral Thinking)	10	Come up with one out-of-the-box idea that can significantly shift the outcome.
Vertical (Small) Solutions	5	Break down the problem into smaller, actionable solutions.
High-Level Solution Overview	5	Provide a broad picture of how the solution will function at a high level.

Prototyping is a “Good to have” until and unless the group doesn't have clarity on above mentioned things, don't jump to the Prototyping, designing random solution without detailed flow and understanding doesn't makes sense (Remember Effort x ROI)

Final Submission: – Submit a complete document including, a detailed solution

Timelines

1. PRD Deadline: **Feb 21, 2026, by 11:59 PM**
2. PPT Presentation: **Feb 22, 2026, 11:00 AM** (You can make the PPT till 11:00 AM on Sunday, there is no deadline for this till the actual time of presentation, kindly submit the PPT after the session on Sunday in the same google drive link)
3. Early submissions will receive additional weighting in evaluation.
4. External References: Use relevant references, such as press releases, case studies, or articles on similar recommendation systems.

Requirement is to have a PRD which you submit on Saturday and make a PPT to show your work on Sunday and a person will present this from your group.

References

1. <https://netflixtechblog.com/tagged/personalization>
2. <https://newsroom.tiktok.com/en-us/how-tiktok-recommends-videos-for-you>
3. <https://blog.youtube/inside-youtube/on-youtubes-recommendation-system/>
4. <https://engineering.atspotify.com/2021/12/how-spotify-uses-ml-to-create-the-future-of-personalization/>
5. <https://engineering.fb.com/2023/08/09/ml-applications/scaling-instagram-explore-recommendations-system/>